

Microsoft greatly enhanced Xbox Live, offering the core capabilities and experiences that Xbox 360 gamers still enjoy today.

Microsoft also offers two types of Xbox Live accounts, a free Silver account type and a paid Gold account type. Xbox Live Gold members represent a little over half the subscriber base. Of course, Xbox Live Gold subscribers must get something for their troubles. Microsoft rewards its paying customers with some unique features, most of which fall into two neat categories: Multi-player online games (the Xbox 360's traditional hardcore audience) and forward-leaning multimedia and social networking features (one potential future for the Xbox 360).

On the gameplay side, Xbox Live Gold subscribers get online multi-player gaming, party and party chat functionality and video chat capabilities. When you sign up with Xbox Live, you must create an Xbox Live account. What this really means is that you're creating a Windows Live ID, because Xbox Live – like Windows Live, Zune and other Microsoft services – simply uses the same underlying identification service. So at the time of sign-up, you can use your own email account, no matter where it's from, and Xbox Live will turn that email address into a Windows Live ID. Or, if you already have a Windows Live ID, through Hotmail or MSN, you can simply use your existing account.

Xbox Live accounts

Each Xbox Live account consists of the following general features:

- ▶ **Gamertag:** This is your identity or name on Xbox Live, and it maps to the name you've established for your Windows Live ID. If you're not happy with this name, you can change it, but Microsoft charges in order to prevent kids from constantly changing their names.



Your avatar can be made to resemble you